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57 YEARS

SEMESTER III / General English III / Subject Code: 25UGEFC3C03/3S03

SYLLABUS

UNIT I – Life Story **15Hrs**

- Wings of Fire (chapter 1 & 2) – A.P.J. Abdul Kalam
- The Test of my Life (chapter 6) - Yuvaraj Singh
- I am Malala (Epilogue)– Malala Yousafzai

UNIT II – Reflections Through Verse **15Hrs**

- The Rainy Day - H. W. Longfellow
- Our Casuarina Tree – Toru Dutt
- If – Rudyard Kipling

UNIT III – Drama **15Hrs**

- Dance Like a Man - Mahesh Dattani

UNIT IV – Fiction **15Hrs**

- Animal Farm- George Orwell (Graphic novel)

UNIT V – Communicative Component –V **15Hrs**

- Mirroring (L)
- Intrigue - Secret Listening (L)
- Speech Organization (S)
- Letters - Types (Appreciation, Requisition, Complaint, Thanking, Negotiation, Follow-up) (W)
- Invitation - Acceptance & Decline (W)

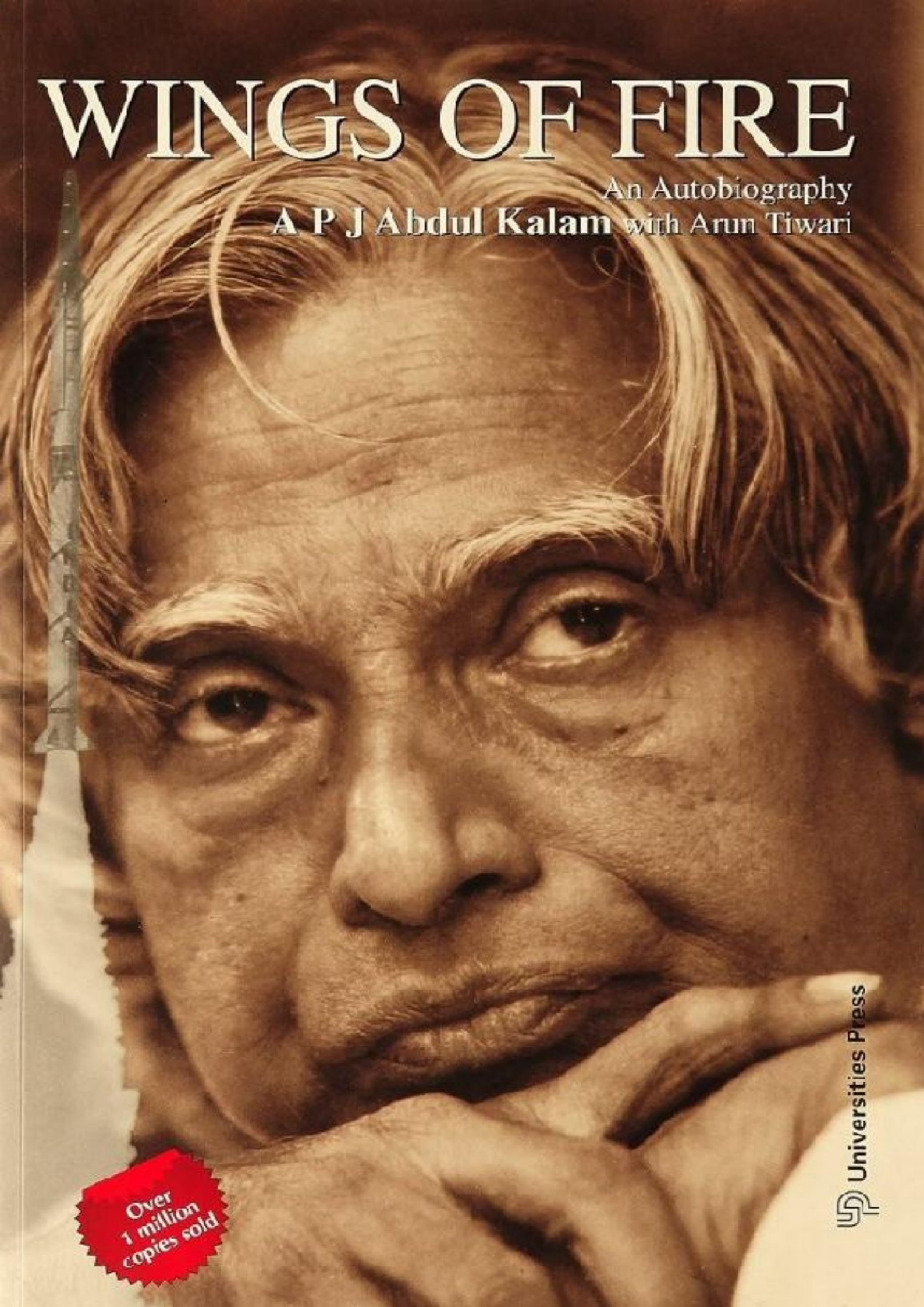
UNIT I – Life Story

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WINGS OF FIRE

An Autobiography

A P J Abdul Kalam with Arun Tiwari



Over 1 million copies sold

Universities Press

1

I was born into a middle-class Tamil family in the island town of Rameswaram in the erstwhile Madras state. My father, Jainulabdeen, had neither much formal education nor much wealth; despite these disadvantages, he possessed great innate wisdom and a true generosity of spirit. He had an ideal helpmate in my mother, Ashiamma. I do not recall the exact number of people she fed every day, but I am quite certain that far more outsiders ate with us than all the members of our own family put together.

My parents were widely regarded as an ideal couple. My mother's lineage was the more distinguished, one of her forebears having been bestowed the title of 'Bahadur' by the British.

I was one of many children—a short boy with rather undistinguished looks, born to tall and handsome parents. We lived in our ancestral house, which was built in the middle of the 19th century. It was a fairly large pucca house, made of limestone and brick, on the Mosque Street in Rameswaram. My austere father used to avoid all inessential comforts and luxuries. However, all necessities were provided for, in terms of food, medicine or clothes. In fact, I would say mine was a very secure childhood, both materially and emotionally.

I normally ate with my mother, sitting on the floor of the kitchen. She would place a banana leaf before me, on which she then ladled rice and aromatic sambhar, a variety of sharp, home-made pickles and a dollop of fresh coconut chutney.

The famous Shiva temple, which made Rameswaram so sacred to pilgrims, was about a ten-minute walk from our house. Our locality was predominantly Muslim, but there were quite a few Hindu families too, living amicably with their Muslim neighbours. There was a very old mosque in our locality where my father would take me for evening prayers.

I had not the faintest idea of the meaning of the Arabic prayers chanted, but I was totally convinced that they reached God. When my father came out of the mosque after the prayers, people of different religions would be sitting outside, waiting for him. Many of them offered bowls of water to my father who would dip his fingertips in them and say a prayer. This water was then carried home for invalids. I also remember people visiting our home to offer thanks after being cured. My father always smiled and asked them to thank Allah, the benevolent and merciful.

The high priest of Rameswaram temple, Pakshi Lakshmana Sastry, was a very close friend of my father's. One of the most vivid memories of my early childhood is of the two men, each in his traditional attire, discussing spiritual matters. When I was old enough to ask questions, I asked my father about the relevance of prayer. My father told me there was nothing mysterious about prayer. Rather, prayer made possible a communion of the spirit between people. "When you pray," he said, "you transcend your body and become a part of the cosmos, which knows no division of wealth, age, caste, or creed."

My father could convey complex spiritual concepts in very simple, down-to-earth Tamil. He once told me, "In his own time, in his own place, in what he really is, and in the stage he has reached—good or bad—every human being is a specific element within the whole of the manifest divine Being. So why be afraid of difficulties, sufferings and problems? When troubles come, try to understand the relevance of your sufferings. Adversity always presents opportunities for introspection."

"Why don't you say this to the people who come to you for help and advice?" I asked my father. He put his hands on my shoulders and looked straight into my eyes. For quite some time he said nothing, as if he was judging my capacity to comprehend his words. Then he answered in a low, deep voice. His answer filled me with a strange energy and enthusiasm:

Whenever human beings find themselves alone, as a natural reaction, they start looking for company. Whenever they are in trouble, they look for someone to help them. Whenever they reach an impasse, they look to someone to show them the way out. Every recurrent anguish, longing, and desire finds its own special helper. For the people who come to me in

distress, I am but a go-between in their effort to propitiate demonic forces with prayers and offerings. This is not a correct approach at all and should never be followed. One must understand the difference between a fear-ridden vision of destiny and the vision that enables us to seek the enemy of fulfilment within ourselves.

I remember my father starting his day at 4 a.m. by reading the namaz before dawn. After the namaz, he used to walk down to a small coconut grove we owned, about 4 miles from our home. He would return, with about a dozen coconuts tied together thrown over his shoulder, and only then would he have his breakfast. This remained his routine even when he was in his late sixties.

I have throughout my life tried to emulate my father in my own world of science and technology. I have endeavoured to understand the fundamental truths revealed to me by my father, and feel convinced that there exists a divine power that can lift one up from confusion, misery, melancholy and failure, and guide one to one's true place. And once an individual severs his emotional and physical bondage, he is on the road to freedom, happiness and peace of mind.

I was about six years old when my father embarked on the project of building a wooden sailboat to take pilgrims from Rameswaram to Dhanuskodi, (also called Sethukkarai), and back. He worked at building the boat on the seashore, with the help of a relative, Ahmed Jallaluddin, who later married my sister, Zohara. I watched the boat take shape. The wooden hull and bulkheads were seasoned with the heat from wood fires. My father was doing good business with the boat when, one day, a cyclone bringing winds of over 100 miles per hour carried away our boat, along with some of the landmass of Sethukkarai. The Pamban Bridge collapsed with a train full of passengers on it. Until then, I had only seen the beauty of the sea, now its uncontrollable energy came as a revelation to me.

By the time the boat met its untimely end, Ahmed Jallaluddin had become a close friend of mine, despite the difference in our ages. He was about 15 years older than I and used to call me Azad. We used to go for long walks together every evening. As we started from Mosque Street and made our way towards the sandy shores of the island, Jallaluddin and I talked mainly

of spiritual matters. The atmosphere of Rameswaram, with its flocking pilgrims, was conducive to such discussion. Our first halt would be at the imposing temple of Lord Shiva. Circling around the temple with the same reverence as any pilgrim from a distant part of the country, we felt a flow of energy pass through us.

Jallaluddin would talk about God as if he had a working partnership with Him. He would present all his doubts to God as if He were standing nearby to dispose of them. I would stare at Jallaluddin and then look towards the large groups of pilgrims around the temple, taking holy dips in the sea, performing rituals and reciting prayers with a sense of respect towards the same Unknown, whom we treat as the formless Almighty. I never doubted that the prayers in the temple reached the same destination as the ones offered in our mosque. I only wondered whether Jallaluddin had any other special connection to God. Jallaluddin's schooling had been limited, principally because of his family's straitened circumstances. This may have been the reason why he always encouraged me to excel in my studies and enjoyed my success vicariously. Never did I find the slightest trace of resentment in Jallaluddin for his deprivation. Rather, he was always full of gratitude for whatever life had chosen to give him.

Incidentally, at the time I speak of, he was the only person on the entire island who could write English. He wrote letters for almost anybody in need, be they letters of application or otherwise. Nobody of my acquaintance, either in my family or in the neighbourhood even had Jallaluddin's level of education or any links of consequence with the outside world. Jallaluddin always spoke to me about educated people, of scientific discoveries, of contemporary literature, and of the achievements of medical science. It was he who made me aware of a "brave, new world" beyond our narrow confines.

In the humble environs of my boyhood, books were a scarce commodity. By local standards, however, the personal library of STR Manickam, a former 'revolutionary' or militant nationalist, was sizeable. He encouraged me to read all I could and I often visited his home to borrow books.

Another person who greatly influenced my boyhood was my first cousin, Samsuddin. He was the sole distributor for newspapers in Rameswaram.

The newspapers would arrive at Rameswaram station by the morning train from Pamban. Samsuddin's newspaper agency was a one-man organization catering to the reading demands of the 1,000-strong literate population of Rameswaram town. These newspapers were mainly bought to keep abreast of current developments in the National Independence Movement, for astrological reference or to check the bullion rates prevailing in Madras. A few readers with a more cosmopolitan outlook would discuss Hitler, Mahatma Gandhi and Jinnah; almost all would finally flow into the mighty political current of Periyar EV Ramaswamy's movement against high caste Hindus. Dinamani was the most sought after newspaper. Since reading the printed matter was beyond my capability, I had to satisfy myself with glancing at the pictures in the newspaper before Samsuddin delivered them to his customers.

The Second World War broke out in 1939, when I was eight years old. For reasons I have never been able to understand, a sudden demand for tamarind seeds erupted in the market. I used to collect the seeds and sell them to a provision shop on Mosque Street. A day's collection would fetch me the princely sum of one anna. Jallaluddin would tell me stories about the war which I would later attempt to trace in the headlines in Dinamani. Our area, being isolated, was completely unaffected by the war. But soon India was forced to join the Allied Forces and something like a state of emergency was declared. The first casualty came in the form of the suspension of the train halt at Rameswaram station. The newspapers now had to be bundled and thrown out from the moving train on the Rameswaram Road between Rameswaram and Dhanuskodi. That forced Samsuddin to look for a helping hand to catch the bundles and, as if naturally, I filled the slot. Samsuddin helped me earn my first wages. Half a century later, I can still feel the surge of pride in earning my own money for the first time.

Every child is born, with some inherited characteristics, into a specific socio-economic and emotional environment, and trained in certain ways by figures of authority. I inherited honesty and self-discipline from my father; from my mother, I inherited faith in goodness and deep kindness and so did my three brothers and sister. But it was the time I spent with Jallaluddin and Samsuddin that perhaps contributed most to the uniqueness of my

childhood and made all the difference in my later life. The unschooled wisdom of Jallaluddin and Samsuddin was so intuitive and responsive to non-verbal messages, that I can unhesitatingly attribute my subsequently manifested creativity to their company in my childhood.

I had three close friends in my childhood—Ramanadha Sastry, Aravindan, and Sivaprakasan. All these boys were from orthodox Hindu Brahmin families. As children, none of us ever felt any difference amongst ourselves because of our religious differences and upbringing. In fact, Ramanadha Sastry was the son of Pakshi Lakshmana Sastry, the high priest of the Rameswaram temple. Later, he took over the priesthood of the Rameswaram temple from his father; Aravindan went into the business of arranging transport for visiting pilgrims; and Sivaprakasan became a catering contractor for the Southern Railways.

During the annual Shri Sita Rama Kalyanam ceremony, our family used to arrange boats with a special platform for carrying idols of the Lord from the temple to the marriage site, situated in the middle of the pond called Rama Tirtha which was near our house. Events from the Ramayana and from the life of the Prophet were the bedtime stories my mother and grandmother would tell the children in our family.

One day when I was in the fifth standard at the Rameswaram Elementary School, a new teacher came to our class. I used to wear a cap which marked me as a Muslim, and I always sat in the front row next to Ramanadha Sastry, who wore a sacred thread. The new teacher could not stomach a Hindu priest’s son sitting with a Muslim boy. In accordance with our social ranking as the new teacher saw it, I was asked to go and sit on the back bench. I felt very sad, and so did

Ramanadha Sastry. He looked utterly downcast as I shifted to my seat in the last row. The image of him weeping when I shifted to the last row left a lasting impression on me.

After school, we went home and told our respective parents about the incident. Lakshmana Sastry summoned the teacher, and in our presence, told the teacher that he should not spread the poison of social inequality and communal intolerance in the minds of innocent children. He bluntly asked

the teacher to either apologize or quit the school and the island. Not only did the teacher regret his behaviour, but the strong sense of conviction Lakshmana Sastry conveyed ultimately reformed this young teacher.

On the whole, the small society of Rameswaram was highly stratified and very rigid in terms of the segregation of different social groups. However, my science teacher Sivasubramania Iyer, though an orthodox Brahmin with a very conservative wife, was something of a rebel. He did his best to break social barriers so that people from varying backgrounds could mingle easily. He used to spend hours with me and would say, “Kalam, I want you to develop so that you are on par with the highly educated people of the big cities.”

One day, he invited me to his home for a meal. His wife was horrified at the idea of a Muslim boy being invited to dine in her ritually pure kitchen. She refused to serve me in her kitchen. Sivasubramania Iyer was not perturbed, nor did he get angry with his wife, but instead, served me with his own hands and sat down beside me to eat his meal. His wife watched us from behind the kitchen door. I wondered whether she had observed any difference in the way I ate rice, drank water or cleaned the floor after the meal. When I was leaving his house, Sivasubramania Iyer invited me to join him for dinner again the next weekend. Observing my hesitation, he told me not to get upset, saying, “Once you decide to change the system, such problems have to be confronted.” When I visited his house the next week, Sivasubramania Iyer’s wife took me inside her kitchen and served me food with her own hands.

Then the Second World War was over and India’s freedom was imminent. “Indians will build their own India,” declared Gandhiji. The whole country was filled with an unprecedented optimism. I asked my father’s permission to leave Rameswaram and study at the district headquarters in Ramanathapuram.

He told me as if thinking aloud, “Abul! I know you have to go away to grow. Does the seagull not fly across the Sun, alone and without a nest? You must forego your longing for the land of your memories to move into the dwelling place of your greater desires; our love will not bind you nor will our needs hold you.” He quoted Khalil Gibran to my hesitant mother,

“Your children are not your children. They are the sons and daughters of Life’s longing for itself. They come through you but not from you. You may give them your love but not your thoughts. For they have their own thoughts.”

He took me and my three brothers to the mosque and recited the prayer Al Fatiha from the Holy Qur’an. As he put me on the train at Rameswaram station he said, “This island may be housing your body but not your soul. Your soul dwells in the house of tomorrow which none of us at Rameswaram can visit, not even in our dreams. May God bless you, my child!”

Samsuddin and Ahmed Jallaluddin travelled with me to Ramanathapuram to enrol me in Schwartz High School, and to arrange for my boarding there. Somehow, I did not take to the new setting. The town of Ramanathapuram was a thriving, factious town of some fifty thousand people, but the coherence and harmony of Rameswaram was absent. I missed my home and grabbed every opportunity to visit Rameswaram. The pull of educational opportunities at Ramanathapuram was not strong enough to nullify the attraction of poli, a South Indian sweet my mother made. In fact, she used to prepare twelve distinctly different varieties of it, bringing out the flavour of every single ingredient used in the best possible combinations.

Despite my homesickness, I was determined to come to terms with the new environment because I knew my father had invested great hopes in my success. My father visualized me as a Collector in the making and I thought it my duty to realise my father’s dream, although I desperately missed the familiarity, security and comforts of Rameswaram.

Jallaluddin used to speak to me about the power of positive thinking and I often recalled his words when I felt homesick or dejected. I tried hard to do as he said, which was to strive to control my thoughts and my mind and, through these, to influence my destiny. Ironically, that destiny did not lead me back to Rameswaram, but rather, swept me farther away from the home of my childhood.

2

Once I settled down at the Schwartz High School, Ramanathapuram, the enthusiastic fifteen-year-old within me re-emerged. My teacher, Iyadurai Solomon, was an ideal guide for an eager young mind that was yet uncertain of the possibilities and alternatives that lay before it. He made his students feel very comfortable in class with his warm and open-minded attitude. He used to say that a good student could learn more from a bad teacher than a poor student from even a skilled teacher.

During my stay at Ramanathapuram, my relationship with him grew beyond that of teacher and pupil. In his company, I learnt that one could exercise enormous influence over the events of one's own life. Iyadurai Solomon used to say, "To succeed in life and achieve results, you must understand and master three mighty forces— desire, belief, and expectation." Iyadurai Solomon, who later became a Reverend, taught me that before anything I wanted could happen, I had to desire it intensely and be absolutely certain it would happen. To take an example from my own life, I had been fascinated by the mysteries of the sky and the flight of birds from early childhood. I used to watch cranes and seagulls soar into flight and longed to fly. Simple, provincial boy though I was, I was convinced that one day I, too, would soar up into the skies. Indeed, I was the first child from Rameswaram to fly.

Iyadurai Solomon was a great teacher because he instilled in all the children a sense of their own worth. Solomon raised my self-esteem to a high point and convinced me, the son of parents who had not had the benefits of education, that I too could aspire to become whatever I wished. "With faith, you can change your destiny," he would say.

One day, when I was in the fourth form, my mathematics teacher, Ramakrishna Iyer, was teaching another class. Inadvertently, I wandered into that classroom and in the manner of an old-fashioned despot, Ramakrishna Iyer caught me by the neck and caned me in front of the whole class. Many months later, when I scored full marks in mathematics, he narrated the

incident to the entire school at morning assembly. “Whomsoever I cane becomes a great man! Take my word, this boy is going to bring glory to his school and to his teachers.” His praise quite made up for the earlier humiliation!

By the time I completed my education at Schwartz, I was a self- confident boy determined to succeed. The decision to go in for further education was taken without a second thought. To us, in those days, the awareness of the possibilities for a professional education did not exist; higher education simply meant going to college. The nearest college was at Tiruchchirappalli, spelled Trichinopoly those days, and called Trichi for short.

In 1950, I arrived at St. Joseph’s College, Trichi, to study for the Intermediate examination. I was not a bright student in terms of examination grades but, thanks to my two buddies back in Rameswaram, I had acquired a practical bent of mind.

Whenever I returned to Rameswaram from Schwartz, my elder brother Mustafa Kamal, who ran a provision store on the railway station road, would call me in to give him a little help and then vanish for hours together leaving the shop in my charge. I sold oil, onions, rice and everything else. The fastest moving items, I found, were cigarettes and bidis. I used to wonder what made poor people smoke away their hard- earned money. When spared by Mustafa, I would be put in charge of his kiosk by my younger brother, Kasim Mohammed. There I sold novelties made of seashells.

At St. Joseph’s, I was lucky to find a teacher like the Rev. Father TN Sequeira. He taught us English and was also our hostel warden. We were about a hundred boys living in the three-storeyed hostel building. Rev. Father used to visit each boy every night with a Bible in his hand. His energy and patience was amazing. He was a very considerate person who took care of even the most minute requirements of his students. On Deepavali, on his instructions, the Brother in charge of the hostel and the mess volunteers would visit each room and distribute good gingelly oil for the ritual bath.

I stayed on the St. Joseph’s campus for four years and shared my room with two others. One was an orthodox Iyengar from Srirangam and the other a Syrian Christian from Kerala. The three of us had a wonderful time together.

When I was made secretary of the vegetarian mess during my third year in the hostel, we invited the Rector, Rev. Father Kalathil, over for lunch one Sunday. Our menu included the choicest preparations from our diverse backgrounds. The result was rather unexpected, but Rev. Father was lavish in his praise of our efforts. We enjoyed every moment with Rev. Father Kalathil, who participated in our unsophisticated conversation with childlike enthusiasm. It was a memorable event for us all.

My teachers at St. Joseph were the true followers of Kanchi Paramacharya, who evoked people to “enjoy the action of giving”. The vivid memory of our mathematics teachers, Prof. Thothathri Iyengar and Prof. Suryanarayana Sastry, walking together on the campus inspires me to this day.

When I was in the final year at St. Joseph’s, I acquired a taste for English literature. I began to read the great classics, Tolstoy, Scott and Hardy being special favourites despite their exotic settings, and then I moved on to some works in Philosophy. It was around this time that I developed a great interest in Physics.

The lessons on subatomic physics at St. Joseph’s by my physics teachers, Prof. Chinna Durai and Prof. Krishnamurthy, introduced me to the concept of the half-life period and matters related to the radioactive decay of substances. Sivasubramania Iyer, my science teacher at Rameswaram, had never taught me that most subatomic particles are unstable and that they disintegrate after a certain time into other particles. All this I was learning for the first time. But when he taught me to strive with diligence because decay is inherent in all compounded things, was he not talking of the same thing? I wonder why some people tend to see science as something which takes man away from God. As I look at it, the path of science can always wind through the heart. For me, science has always been the path to spiritual enrichment and self-realisation.

Even the rational thought-matrices of science have been home to fairy tales. I am an avid reader of books on cosmology and enjoy reading about celestial bodies. Many friends, while asking me questions related to space flights, sometimes slip into astrology. Quite honestly, I have never really understood the reason behind the great importance attached by people to the faraway planets in our solar system. As an art, I have nothing against astrology, but if

it seeks acceptance under the guise of science, I reject it. I do not know how these myths evolved about planets, star constellations, and even satellites—that they can exercise power on human beings. The highly complicated calculations manipulated around the precise movements of celestial bodies, to derive highly subjective conclusions appear illogical to me. As I see it, the Earth is the most powerful and energetic planet. As John Milton puts it so beautifully in Paradise Lost, Book VIII:

. . . What if the Sun
Be centre to the World, and other stars . . . . .
The planet earth, so steadfast though she seem,
In sensibly three different motions move?

Wherever you go on this planet, there is movement and life. Even apparently inanimate things like rocks, metal, timber, clay are full of intrinsic movement—with electrons dancing around each nucleus. This motion originates in their response to the confinement imposed on them by the nucleus, by means of electric forces which try to hold them as close as possible. Electrons, just like any individual with a certain amount of energy, detest confinement. The tighter the electrons are held by the nucleus, the higher their orbital velocity will be: in fact, the confinement of electrons in an atom results in enormous velocities of about 1000 km per second! These high velocities make the atom appear a rigid sphere, just as a fast-moving fan appears like a disc. It is very difficult to compress atoms more strongly —thus giving matter its familiar solid aspect. Everything solid, thus, contains much empty space within and everything stationary contains great movement within. It is as though the great dance of Shiva is being performed on earth during every moment of our existence.

When I joined the B.Sc. degree course at St.Joseph’s, I was unaware of any other option for higher education. Nor did I have any information about career opportunities available to a student of science. Only after obtaining a B.Sc. did I realise that physics was not my subject. I had to go into engineering to realise my dreams. I could have joined the Engineering course long ago, right after finishing my Intermediate course. Better late than never, I told myself as I made the detour, applying for admission into the Madras Institute of Technology (MIT), regarded as the crown jewel of technical education in South India at that time.

I managed to be on the list of selected candidates, but admission to this prestigious institution was an expensive affair. Around a thousand rupees was required, and my father could not spare that much money. At that time, my sister, Zohara, stood behind me, mortgaging her gold bangles and chain. I was deeply touched by her determination to see me educated and by her faith in my abilities. I vowed to release her bangles from mortgage with my own earnings. The only way before me to earn money at that point of time was to study hard and get a scholarship. I went ahead at full steam.

What fascinated me most at MIT was the sight of two decommissioned aircraft displayed there for the demonstration of the various subsystems of flying machines. I felt a strange attraction towards them, and would sit near them long after other students had gone back to the hostel, admiring man's will to fly free in the sky, like a bird. After completing my first year, when I had to opt for a specific branch, I almost spontaneously chose aeronautical engineering. The goal was very clear in my mind now; I was going to fly aircraft. I was convinced of this, despite being aware of my lack of assertiveness, which probably came about because of my humble background. Around this time, I made special efforts to try and communicate with different kinds of people. There were setbacks, disappointments and distractions, but my father's inspiring words anchored me in those periods of nebulous drift.

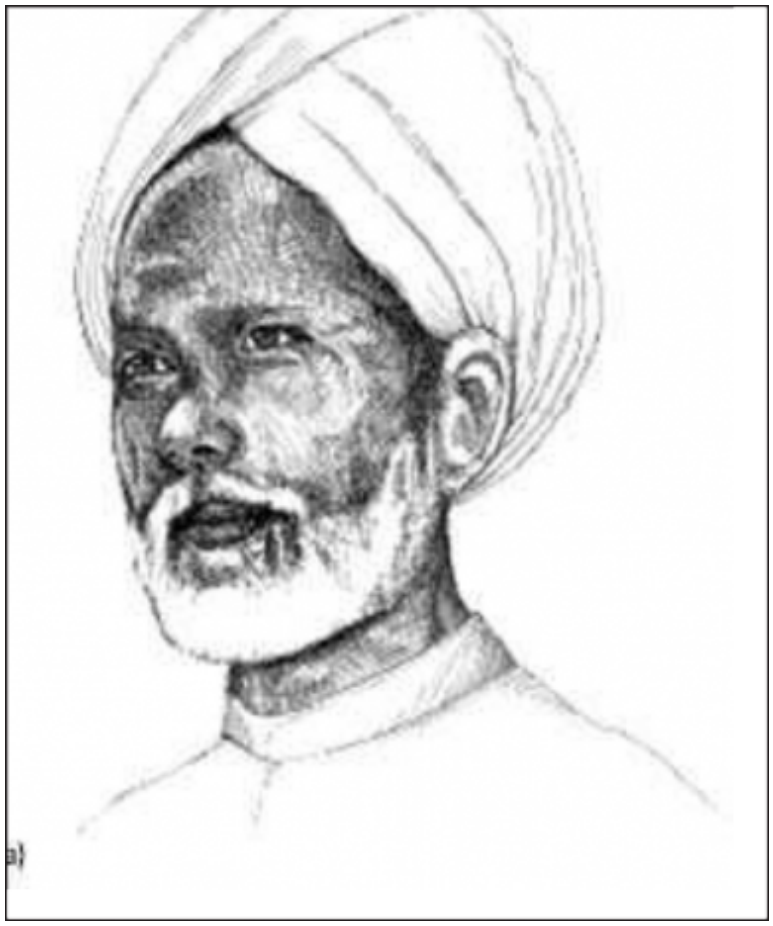






Plate 1 (a) My father Jainulabdeen was not formally educated, but was a man of great wisdom and kindness. (b) Pakshi Lakshmana Sastry, a close friend of my father and the head priest of the Rameswaram Temple.





Plate 2 The locality in which I grew up: (a) My house on Mosque Street. (b) Thousands of pilgrims from great distances descend on the ancient temple of Lord Shiva. I often assisted my brother Kasim Mohamed in his shop selling artifacts on this street.



Plate 3 The old mosque in our locality where my father would take me and my brothers every evening to offer prayers.

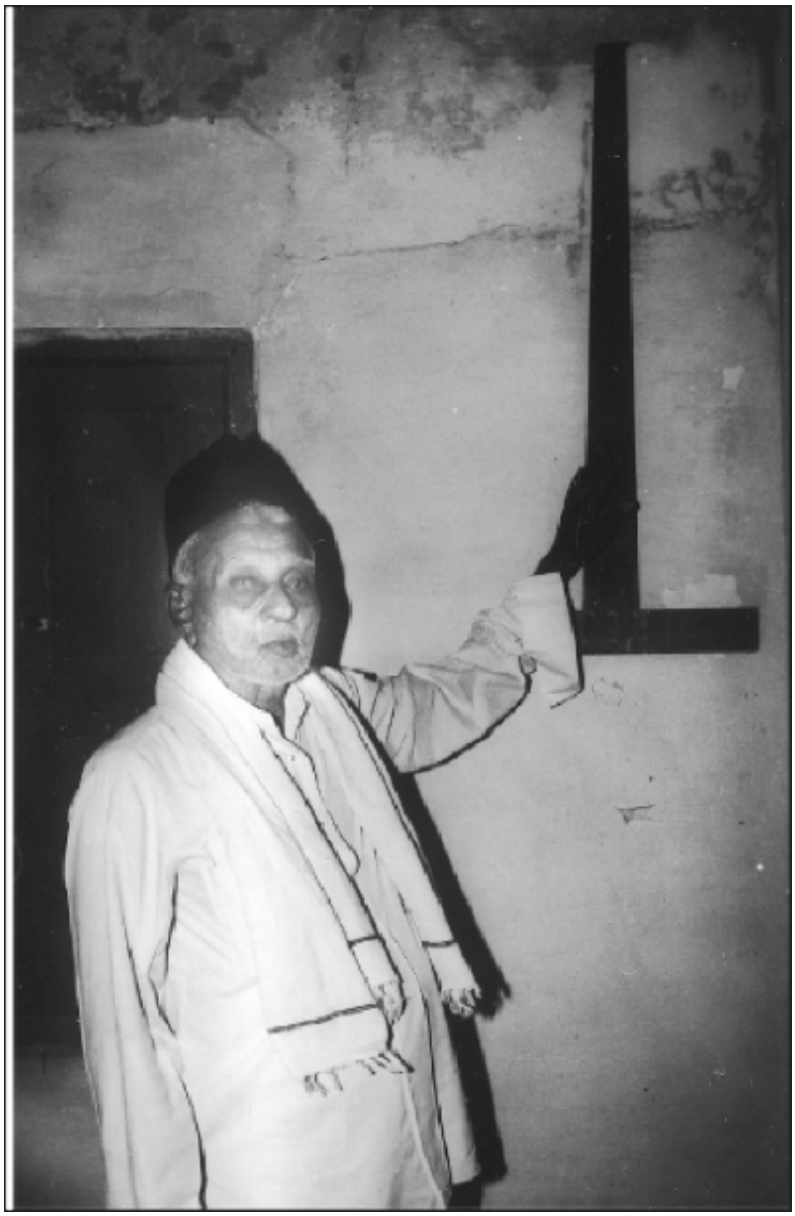


Plate 4 My brother pointing at the T–square I used while studying engineering.



Plate 5 STR Manickam (inset), a friend of my brother Mustafa Kamal, had a large collection of books. This is his house, from where I would borrow books while at Rameswaram.



Plate 6 A family get-together.



Plate 7 The simple surroundings of Schwartz High School, Ramanathapuram. The words on the plaque read "Let not thy winged days be spent in vain. When once gone no gold can buy them back again."



Plate 8 My teachers at Schwartz High School—Iyadurai Solomon (standing, left) and Ramakrishna Iyer (sitting, right). They are the best examples of small-town Indian teachers committed to nurturing talent.

"He who knows others is learned, but the wise one is the one who knows himself. Learning without wisdom is of no use."

In the course of my education at MIT, three teachers shaped my thinking. Their combined contributions formed the foundation on which I later built my professional career. These three teachers were Prof. Sponder, Prof. KAV Pandalai and Prof. Narasingha Rao. Each one of them had very distinct personalities, but they shared a common impulse— the capacity to feed their students' intellectual hunger by sheer brilliance and untiring zeal.

Prof. Sponder taught me technical aerodynamics. He was an Austrian with rich practical experience in aeronautical engineering. During the Second World War, he had been captured by the Nazis and imprisoned in a concentration camp. Understandably, he had developed a very strong dislike for Germans. Inciden- tally, the aeronautical department was headed by a German, Prof. Walter Repenthin. Another well-known professor, Dr Kurt

Tank, was a distinguished aeronautical engineer who had designed the German Focke–Wulf FW 190 single-seater fighter plane, an outstanding combat aircraft of the Second World War. Dr Tank later joined the Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) in Bangalore and was responsible for the design of India's first jet fighter, the HF-24 Marut.

Notwithstanding these irritants, Prof. Sponder preserved his individuality and maintained high professional standards. He was always calm, energetic and in total control of himself. He kept abreast of the latest technologies and expected his students to do the same. I consulted him before opting for aeronautical engineering. He told me that one should never worry about one's future prospects: instead, it was more important to lay sound foundations, to have sufficient enthusiasm and an accompanying passion for one's chosen field of study. The trouble with Indians, Prof. Sponder used to observe, was not that they lacked educational opportunities or industrial infrastructure—the trouble was in their failure to discriminate between disciplines and to rationalise their choices. Why aeronautics? Why not electrical engineering? Why not mechanical engineering? I myself would like to tell all novitiate engineering students that when they choose their specialization, the essential point to consider is whether the choice articulates their inner feelings and aspirations.

Prof. KAV Pandalai taught me aero-structure design and analysis. He was a cheerful, friendly and enthusiastic teacher, who brought a fresh approach to every year's teaching course. It was Professor Pandalai who opened up the secrets of structural engineering to us. Even today I believe that everyone who has been taught by Prof. Pandalai would agree that he was a man of great intellectual integrity and scholarship—but with no trace of arrogance. His students were free to disagree with him on several points in the classroom.

Prof. Narasingha Rao was a mathematician, who taught us theoretical aerodynamics. I still remember his method of teaching fluid dynamics. After attending his classes, I began to prefer mathematical physics to any other subject. Often, I have been told I carry a "surgical knife" to aeronautical design reviews. If it had not been for Prof. Rao's kind and persistent advice on picking up proofs to equations of aerodynamic flow, I would not have acquired this metaphorical tool.

Aeronautics is a fascinating subject, containing within it the promise of freedom. The great difference between freedom and escape, between motion and movement, between slide and flow are the secrets of this science. My teachers revealed these truths to me. Through their meticulous teaching, they created within me an excitement about aeronautics. Their intellectual fervour, clarity of thought and passion for perfection helped me to launch into a serious study of fluid dynamics- modes of compressible medium motion, development of shock waves and shock, induced flow separation at increasing speeds, shock stall and shock-wave drag.

Slowly, a great amalgamation of information took place in my mind. The structural features of aeroplanes began to gain new meanings— biplanes, monoplanes, tailless planes, canard configured planes, delta- wing planes, all these began to assume increasing significance for me. The three teachers, all of them authorities in their different fields, helped me to mould a composite knowledge.

My third and last year at MIT was a year of transition and was to have a great impact on my later life. In those days, a new climate of political enlightenment and industrial effort was sweeping across the country. I had to test my belief in God and see if it could fit into the matrix of scientific thinking. The accepted view was that a belief in scientific methods was the only valid approach to knowledge. If so, I wondered, was matter alone the ultimate reality and were spiritual phenomena but a manifestation of matter? Were all ethical values relative, and was sensory perception the only source of knowledge and truth? I wondered about these issues, attempting to sort out the vexing question of “scientific temper” and my own spiritual interests. The value system in which I had been nurtured was profoundly religious. I had been taught that true reality lay beyond the material world in the spiritual realm, and that knowledge could be obtained only through inner experience.

Meanwhile, when I had finished my course work, I was assigned a project to design a low-level attack aircraft together with four other colleagues. I had taken up the responsibility of preparing and drawing the aerodynamic design. My team mates distributed among themselves the tasks of designing the propulsion, structure, control and instrumentation of the aircraft. One day, my design teacher, Prof. Srinivasan, then the Director of the MIT,

reviewed my progress and declared it dismal and disappointing. I offered a dozen excuses for the delay, but none of them impressed Prof. Srinivasan. I finally pleaded for a month's time to complete the task. The Professor looked at me for some time and said, "Look, young man, today is Friday afternoon. I give you three days' time. If by Monday morning I don't get the configuration drawing, your scholarship will be stopped." I was dumbstruck. The scholarship was my lifeline and I would be quite helpless if it was withdrawn. I could see no other way out but to finish the task as I had been instructed. That night, I remained at the drawing board, skipping dinner. Next morning, I took only an hour's break to freshen up and eat a little food. On Sunday morning, I was very near completion, when suddenly I felt someone else's presence in the room. Prof. Srinivasan was watching me from a distance. Coming straight from the gymkhana, he was still in his tennis outfit and had dropped in to see my progress. After examining my work, Prof. Srinivasan hugged me affectionately and patted my back in appreciation. He said, "I knew I was putting you under stress and asking you to meet an impossible deadline. I never expected you to perform so well."

During the rest of the period of the project, I participated in an essay competition organized by the MIT Tamil Sangam (Literary Society). Tamil is my mother tongue and I am proud of its origins, which have been traced back to Sage Agastya in the pre-Ramayana period; its literature dates back to the fifth century BC. It is said to be a language moulded by lawyers and grammarians and is internationally acclaimed for its clear-cut logic. I was very enthusiastic about ensuring that science did not remain outside the purview of this wonderful language. I wrote an article entitled "Let Us Make Our Own Aircraft" in Tamil. The article evoked much interest and I won the competition, taking the first prize from 'Devan', the editor of the popular Tamil weekly, Ananda Vikatan.

My most touching memory of MIT is related to Prof. Sponder. We were posing for a group photograph as part of a farewell ritual. All the graduating students had lined up in three rows with the professors seated in the front. Suddenly, Prof. Sponder got up and looked for me. I was standing in the third row. "Come and sit with me in the front," he said. I was taken aback by Prof. Sponder's invitation. "You are my best student and hard work will help you bring a great name for your teachers in future." Embarrassed by the praise but honoured by the recognition, I sat with Prof. Sponder for the

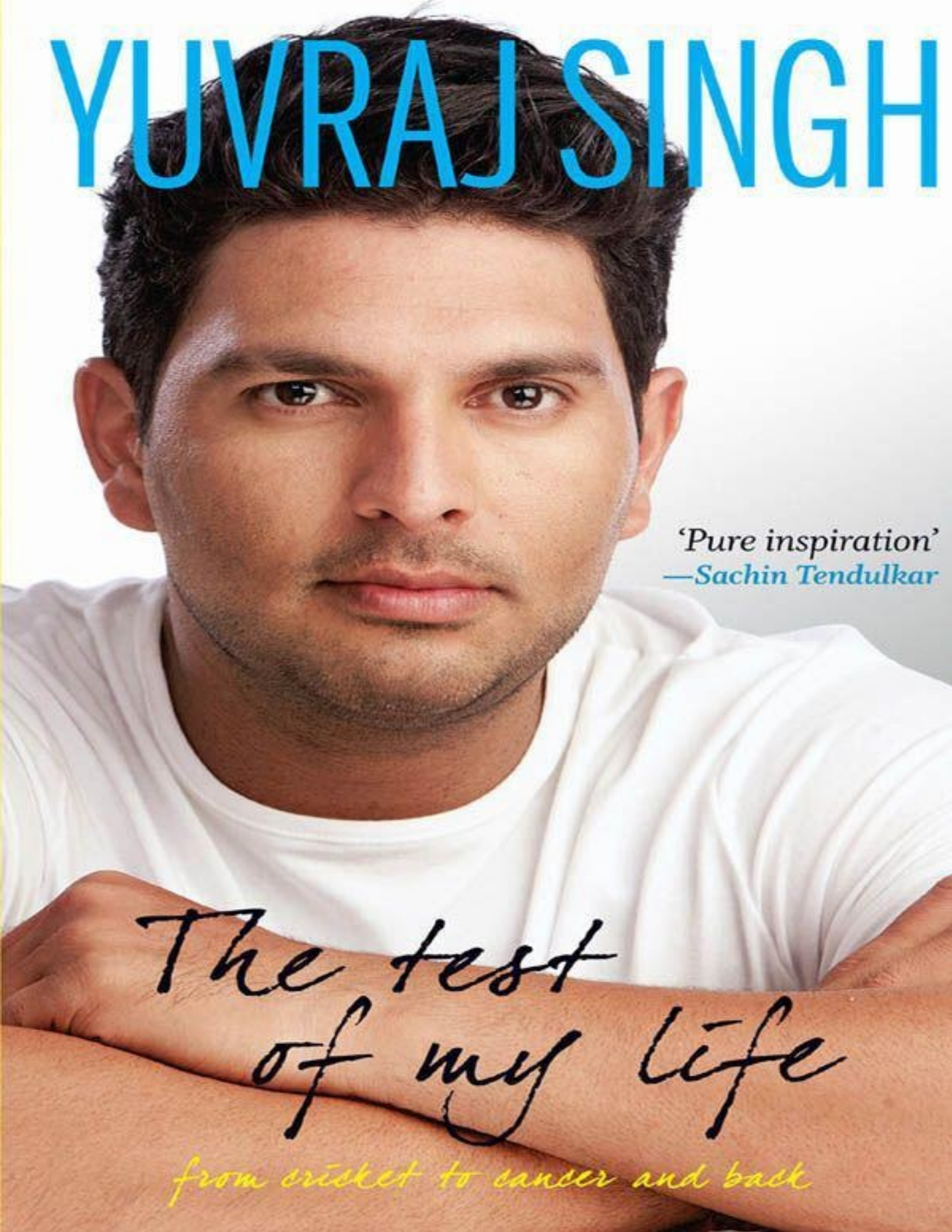
photograph. “Let God be your hope, your stay, your guide and provide the lantern for your feet in your journey into the future,” said the introverted genius, bidding me adieu.

From MIT, I went to Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) at Bangalore as a trainee. There I worked on engine overhauling as part of a team. Hands-on work on aircraft engine overhauling was very educative. When a principle learnt in the classroom is borne out by practical experience, it creates a strange sense of excitement—akin to unexpectedly running into an old friend among a crowd of strangers. At HAL, I worked on the overhauling of both piston and turbine engines. The hazy concepts of gas dynamics and diffusion processes in the working principle of after burning came into sharper focus in my mind. I was also trained in radial engine-cum-drum operations.

I learned how to check a crankshaft for wear and tear, and a connecting rod and crankshaft for twist. I did calibrations of a fixed- pitch fan fitted to a super-charged engine. I opened up pressure and acceleration-cum-speed control systems, and air starter supply systems of turbo-engines. Getting to understand feathering, un-feathering and reversing of propeller engines was very interesting. The demonstration of the delicate art of beta (blade angle control) by HAL technicians still lingers in my memory. They had neither studied in major universities, nor were they merely implementing what their engineer-in-charge was suggesting. They had been working hands-on for years and this had given them something like an intuitive feel for the work.

Two alternative opportunities for employment, both close to my long-standing dream of flying, presented themselves before me when I came out of HAL as a graduate aeronautical engineer. One was a career in the Air Force and another was a job at the Directorate of Technical Development and Production, DTD&P(Air), at the Ministry of Defence. I applied for both. The interview calls arrived from both the places almost simultaneously. I was asked to reach Dehra Dun by the Air Force recruitment authorities and Delhi by DTD&P(Air). The boy from the Coromandel Coast took a train to the North of India. My destination was more than 2000 km away, and was to be my first encounter with the vastness of my motherland.

YUVRAJ SINGH



'Pure inspiration'
—Sachin Tendulkar

The test of my life

from cricket to cancer and back

The test of my life

from cricket to cancer and back

YUVRAJ SINGH

WITH

SHARDA UGRA & NISHANT JEET ARORA



RANDOM HOUSE INDIA

Chapter 6

The Battle for Confidence

ONE AFTERNOON IN AUGUST I went out to the terrace in Gurgaon to check if there was some hint, at least a little smell of rain. Anyone who has lived on this side of the world knows that August is sticky and uncomfortable. If you are playing in India, be sure you will sweat and trickle till there is a puddle in your shoes. The weather is suffocating and you crave a refreshing breeze and a sudden burst of rain.

As I stepped out there was a gust of wind and to my surprise a peacock stood right in front of me. It walked around the terrace completely at ease. I had no idea where it came from. In our mythology a visit by a peacock is a mixed sign. There are many superstitions around it. Depending on what you believe in it can be a good or a bad omen. The peacock walked around my terrace, its crown perched on its head, blue neck glowing, like it was on a business visit. Its feathers were shimmering in the light and I saw streaks of orange and green. The peacock moved with a balance and a lightness of the feet that we batsmen dream of.

Just then I heard Mom shouting for me. 'Mom, upstairs, on the terrace,' I said. From below, I heard her cry, 'Selection, selection!' When she got to the terrace her eyes were shining with joy. She told me I had made it to the Indian team for the World T20. She had seen it on the news. I pointed to the peacock on the terrace. The peacock is a noisy bird and I took it as a representation that in my life cricket would not be silenced. It had been a good omen for me.

Cricket and I. Here we were again. What a difficult journey it had been to this point, and now here we were standing at the start of the old life.

When I first came back from the US, Ashish Kaushik visited me in Gurgaon. No doubt he found a heavy, slow, lethargic Yuvraj. He came as a friend, not as a physiotherapist, but inevitably our talk turned to the comeback. He asked me if I wanted to come to the NCA immediately but I was just too weak at that time. 'I'll come,' I said, 'but after a few weeks, and maybe we could do some tests to see how far I am from …'

From what? In my most private thoughts, I knew that the future looked to me

like a road that runs towards the horizon in a flat open desert and there is no way of knowing the distance to wherever it goes.

Ashish said, ‘What I want is for you to look towards being a normal Yuvraj Singh again. That’s all.’

But normal? Did I really have the courage to come back to the Indian team? It felt a mountain so high and my body felt so feeble that I could not imagine the climb. Being in shape, hitting the ball cleanly, running around on the field easily, being able to last forty overs a day, ninety overs a day, hundred overs a day. How would I ever be able to do it? We talked quite a bit but Ashish said nothing about the plan he had up his sleeve. He said come when you are ready and gave me a few exercises to do on my own. After he left, that night I remembered that Dr Einhorn had taken the trouble to speak to Dr Nitesh about cricket and its demands. He had designed his treatment plan especially for me. The doctors had been thorough and faithful in the mission to give me a treatment that would deposit me back into the normal world as a worldclass athlete. Medicine had given me the body that could do it. Now somehow, somewhere, I had to find the mind.



In the middle of May I decided to make a trip to Bangalore. The summer had begun and soon it would end and the home season would begin with New Zealand in India in August. The World T20 was right after that. It was at the World T20 that I had hit my six sixes in 2007. If I had a big poster I would have put it up on my wall to motivate myself. It was these sixes that I tortured myself with in Indianapolis and it was sixes that I had to get set to hit again. I made up my mind. I told myself, normal is: hit it out of the park. And after that if a friend asked me, ‘So, when do you think you might play again?’, I would grin, ‘Twenty20 World Cup,’ and watch the jaw drop. ‘But … But isn’t that, like, just now? In September?’ ‘Yes sir, it is.’

It so happened that Ishant Sharma was at the NCA in May for rehab following an ankle injury and Ashish asked us to play a match-up with each other, bat versus tennis ball. With his thin, tall frame, flying hair and generally downbeat expression, Ishant reminds me of a moody rock star. I call him Lambu. (Not very original, I know.) At our tennis-ball match-up, as the bright yellow ball left Lambu’s hand, my eyes picked up the line, and my feet and arms moved as if on their own. I found myself hitting through the line; and the ball? It flew over the

ground and over the boundary. From the pit of my stomach rose something that must have been pure joy.

What had just transpired is called ‘muscle memory’ by doctors, but for me it was as if my old life was linking arms with the new one. As that match-up went on, I hit Lambu for seven sixes and he went ballistic. ‘Paaji’, he shouted like fast bowlers do, ‘you are a cheater!’ All I could do was laugh with relief. Whatever else my arms and legs and back may tell me, that day I knew that my mind was all right. I better mention here that Lambu hit me for six sixes when it was his turn.



In June I took my holiday in Spain. Immediately afterwards I checked into the NCA. In Spain when I tried to swim in the hotel pool I would be winded in half a lap. Before cancer, I could clear ten-fifteen breaststroke laps before my breathing changed. At the NCA it became clearer than ever that the parameters I had built around the 2011 World Cup had bottomed out. My endurance levels had gone down drastically and my stability and cardio-vascular strength was practically at zero.

At the NCA a three-man team was in place for my Project T20. Along with Ashish, there were two strength and conditioning coaches: Anand Date and Nagender Prasad. They were smiling and friendly and then they didn’t let me go. They were told, ‘Forget about his cancer’, and they did. They were to think of me as just a regular guy who had not worked out for six months and, boy, did they.

Ashish and I have had an excellent working relationship for a long time, by which I mean I play pranks on him all the time and he never minds it. I have fiddled with his mobile phone several times and sent out prank messages but he still keeps leaving it around. We have nicknamed him Ghajini after the superhit film since he is a habitual offender in forgetting things. He gives me the strictest workouts and routines and if I resist, he totally ignores that. So for all his sweetness and forgiving nature, and his college boy face, Ashish takes no crap when it comes to training.

Before I could return to my cricket skills, I needed to rebuild my fitness around its core, through Pilates, swimming and running. The first few days, my calves were set on fire. In the middle of a set my knees would shake as if I was eighty years old and knives were being thrust into my back. That’s what it felt

like. Often I would haul myself out of the pool and tell Ashish I couldn't do it anymore. Sympathetically he would say ok, take a break, get back your breath. A moment later he would order me back into the pool again.

The Bangalore monsoon came and began its drip-drip. I found the humidity draining on my energy and my general mood. After hours of body-busting training at the NCA, I would go back to my hotel room wiped out. Every evening I felt I was running uphill and my lungs were completely burnt out and I was finding that the uphill track was never going to get to the peak. The road in the desert had become a road on a mountain and still on the sides there was nothing but cactus. Many days I wanted to pick up my bags and go home. I asked myself what were my reasons for wanting to return to competitive cricket. Was I forcing this upon myself for no good reason? If my career were to come to an abrupt end right then, wouldn't I have already got more than I ever dreamt of?

Then I figured that the mind's questions were actually the body's protest. A few hours of rest and the body would be silenced and the mind could easily win the debate. No one had forced me to come to Bangalore or made me give myself a target to go at. I was doing this for myself and for the people around me who had believed in me during cancer and had lived through my pain with their love and patience. Their belief had fuelled my belief and made me want to return to cricket. As much as I loved my life playing the sport and living the life of a sportsman, and as much as cricket had given me my identity, I knew that this time my attempt to come back was not only about me. That this time if I came back, I would be changed. It was not the old life I was trying to get back to. It was a new life that I was trying to reach out to.

Count your blessings, Yuvi, I would tell myself when I crashed on the hotel bed in the evenings feeling sorry for myself. The NCA, Ashish and his team, the work going into me; the BCCI … What if I had been a hockey player, or a runner, or a boxer, or a TT player? What if I had been one of the hundreds of Indian athletes who sacrifice so much for their sport—their youth, their family's entire finances—and what if then I got diagnosed with cancer? What if I had been any Indian sportsman but a cricketer?

There would have been a few articles in the newspaper and some stories on TV. Federation bosses would have perhaps made the right noises and everyone would have clucked in pity. After that my family and my friends would have had to run around trying to get me treated. They would have had to put their own lives on hold. Had I been that other Indian sportsman diagnosed with cancer, I would most likely not have been able to bear what my loved ones would have

had to go through. It would have been easier to give up and walk away from the sport I loved.

My good fortune was to be a cricketer. The BCCI and everyone in it had looked after me like I was someone from their immediate family going through a bad time. They had gone out of their way to guard my privacy, monitor my progress, keep tabs on my treatment, welcome me back, pay for my expenses and then do their best to ensure that I had every possible chance to come back into the game. The BCCI had shown such a large heart that it made me grateful and proud to be an Indian cricketer. In the NCA they had created for us state of the art infrastructure that made it possible for us to rehabilitate ourselves and work on our recovery.

Every day this was why I turned up at the NCA even if I had left the previous evening a creaking mess in the foulest of moods, wanting nothing more than to take a taxi to the airport. Every day I would arrive at the NCA to find Ashish and his team dead set on their schedule. 'Give me a break!' I would say but on no day would they lessen my workload or change it to suit my complaints and pleas. There was a schedule set down for me and that was that. No matter how long it took to do the exercises set out for that day I would have to complete them that day. On some days what should have been over by four in the evening went on till dinner time.

When the guys at the NCA paid no attention to my protesting body, I hit on a clever way to buy time between workouts. I would be at the weights or on the field, and Nagender and Anand would be counting reps or laps, and I would suddenly say, 'Ok, guys, now you explain to me exactly the science behind what we are doing here, and how it is going to help me.' As they struggled, I would rest, rest, rest, my muscles screaming for a warm bath and a soft bed. But Ashish caught on soon enough and orders were given: 'Just ignore him.'

Ashish and I argued a lot about what he thought I could do and what I thought I couldn't. He kept saying *ho jayega*, it will happen, I kept saying *nahin ho sakta*, it is not possible. He kept pushing me and occasionally he would dangle a carrot, tempt me with a small prize. If I finished a really beastly workload on one day, I could take time off another ghastly set the next day. These variations were all a part of their plans actually, but I would think *oh wow!* and work extra hard to get through the first day's stuff. Nice carrots for me he thought up, nice *gajar ka halwa!* And I ate it up gladly.

The plan meant everything. If I did not finish a set of exercises on the day I was meant to, I would have fallen behind on the schedule they had made for me,

and the schedule was based on the deadline I had set for myself. The schedule was so tight that the slightest slip and everything would go haywire. Maybe I would not be ready in time for the home season. Once the season started, and gathered its usual hard momentum, who knows if there would be a chance and when.

So hands to the bar and go, go, go. Weights I found easy, even though right at the beginning my body would quake. But running I would hate. When I was asked to run the first single lap around the Chinnaswamy Stadium, the ground looked enormous, five times its size. I could barely finish the round for the ache in my calves and the burning in my lungs. We began with one lap, then added more, *and* more, a bigger and bigger number, then laps with gaps for other training. The team wanted to take me to a point that I could complete eight rounds of the ground with ease. When I could finally complete those rounds after weeks of slow, tiring, lungripping, muscle-burning attempts, I remembered being in a wheelchair and marvelled at the human body and what it could achieve.



July came. It was our cricket month but I was finding it hard to get past the fear of the ball and of getting hit by it. A goblin sat in my head and told me to back away because if the ball hit me, I would get injured again. To deal with my fear, we decided that I would first do my catching practice with tennis balls and graduate later to the cricket ball. It was like being a kid again but as a kid learning cricket I was not allowed to fear the ball! Wet tennis balls and hard plastic balls were bowled at my head so I would never fear the ball. Who would have thought I would ever fear the ball? Life has a funny way of coming full circle.

In July my weight began to drop too but everyone who saw me, journalists and commentators and my seniors, had one worry. What is the hurry? Aren't you trying to do too much too soon? Take it easy.

I understood the concern so I stopped myself from saying out loud my most truthful answer, because it would have been rude. That was: this is my body and I know what it can do. Instead, when people asked me if I was ready, I said I was training well, my body was responding well, and if they didn't believe me they should take a look at my NCA report.

As for the NCA guys, they knew halfway into August that I would be 100 percent ready for the World T20 but they didn't offer me that comfort so I

plugged away. In addition to the gym and training rehabilitation I started playing in friendlies as well. I played in a friendly practice for a scratch Karnataka side against the India under-19s who were setting off for their World Cup (which they won). I held up ok. The harder twos made me a little breathless but given that two months earlier I couldn't go around the Chinnaswamy even once without gasping and coming to a wheezing halt, hands on knees, head hanging like a shaking leaf, I knew this was not bad. I was getting better and better.

So in August that day when I was in Gurgaon on a brief break and the peacock turned up, as emotional as the call-up was, when the selection committee announced the World T20 squad, it was also not that simple. Comments about my 'emotional' (meaning sentimental) selection began going around on news channels and websites. I thought my selection should be called 'emotional' only because I was so emotional about it. I had been working for this for three straight months and I had met every parameter that Ashish and his team had set for me. I had passed the fitness tests. I had played the matches. What was 'emotional' about my selection?

I wasn't at my leanest but for a short spell of time there I felt at my meanest. I hated being thought of as a charity case selection. What annoyed me was that the people who were throwing the words 'emotional selection' around had not tried to find out what I had been doing. It would have been too much work I guess to make a phone call and ask me or Ashish Kaushik what my state of fitness was.

At twenty years old I would have been driven by my anger. Cricket would have turned into a point-scoring exercise. I would have worked myself into a fit of rage, wanting to prove those guys wrong. Now I am older, and I hope wiser, and I know it is a waste of energy to wake up every day and try to prove yourself worthy to the whole world. And so the anger ebbed away. I decided to live in the moment and enjoy the fruits of my labour. At the same time, I was receiving congratulatory messages from strangers who said they had been praying to see me back on the field. I thought it was best for me to ignore those who did not like my 'emotional selection' and take greater joy from those who celebrated it. I was blessed. I couldn't waste my energy. At this time I needed to concentrate on my cricket. September 8 was knocking on my door. I had a match to play.



The glitch in my memory that was the side effect of chemo continued to create funny and sometimes embarrassing moments for me. I had given a name to it,

calling them my *Ghajini* moments. When I goofed up, I would say I have had a *Ghajini* moment. Ashish used to laugh, saying these moments were his sweet revenge. On the big day when it finally came, SEPTEMBER 8, in the dressing room of the stadium in Visakhapatnam I had a spooky *Ghajini* moment. I got overdressed and realized I had fallen out of touch with my own team's routines. (I'll come to that in a moment.) No one caught on or they would have taken the mickey out of me forever and ever. I would never have lived this one down.

It was a few hours before the match and my return to international cricket. The welcome back into cricket was as if all of India was giving me a giant hug. The guys had been great. There was hugs and back-slapping. They were curious about the cancer and the treatment. What does chemotherapy mean? Why can't one take the medicines orally? Did it have to be intravenous? How the hell did you manage!

When we landed in Visakhapatnam, the large sign outside the airport which says 'Welcome to the City of Destiny' made me smile. It's been there for many years but I had never noticed it before. Now I have started noticing these things. In the City of Destiny, welcoming me was every gateman at every door I walked through, the driver of the team bus, waiters at the hotel, the man on the street, children shrieking and rushing past cops to shake my hand. Buzzed, that's what I was. So highly buzzed that on the day of the match I didn't realize what I was doing. Visakhapatnam's wide indigo sky was filling with clouds but I was pulling on my shoes and my match kit. Normally, on match days, we reach the ground in our training gear, we take our seats, relax, get a bit of food, and then go out for warm-ups. That is the normal routine. But that day I was in such a high state of excitement that I had my playing shoes on and was about to change into the full match uniform when I looked up and saw everyone else around me. They were relaxed, chatting, grabbing a bite, getting their kits sorted out. Outside it was raining.

Whoa, Yuvi. Chill. Take a deep breath. Quickly I slunk back to my spot, changed out of my playing shoes and got ready for the warm-ups. But it kept on raining.

When it rains in Visakhapatnam it is like the rain god has organized a show. The previous evening the sea had been churning up the surf opposite our hotel. When the rain started, it came down in heavenly buckets. Nothing like drizzles or showers here, it was a full stereophonic surround sound concert. The guys started playing one-tip cricket. This is one of the ways we entertain ourselves in the dressing room. We used a tennis ball, batting single-handed. Even on one tip

if the ball is caught, but only with one hand, that is out, so you better hit straight and down. I threw myself into it, everyone else threw themselves into it and soon there was chaos.

A TV floor manager knocked at the dressing room and asked for me. Could I do a live interview with Ravi Shastri? From the sealed off dressing room to the outside was like changing planets. Despite the rain, there were about fifteen thousand people still in the stands and no one was going home. Everywhere I looked and as far as I could see, people were holding up banners with messages for me. 'Goodbye Cancer, Welcome Sixer' said one. Another one wanted me to hit six sixes in an over again. These people had been so patient and kind that later with a helper holding an umbrella over my head I took a lap around the ground waving and waving my hello and thank you to the people in the wet stands. The field was total slush. I stepped out in my chappals but they would get sucked by the mud and stuck to the ground. It had poured for three hours and the ground had turned into a pool. So I took my chappals in my hand and walked all around the perimeter barefoot. I wanted to embrace the stadium, every person in every stand who had stayed back. The last time I had done a lap of honour, it was the 2nd of April 2011, at the Wankhede. As I walked around, the Visakhapatnam crowd got up from their seats as one and started clapping and clapping and clapping. As the sound of people clapping and cheering intensified, I thought my heart would burst.



When we were told that the weather had forced the abandonment of the game I was crushed because I had felt so ready. My family and friends were in the stands. They had come from all over the world to see me play. We had twenty-seven guests that evening; it was like I was going to my wedding. The night before the match, I had emailed the people back in Indianapolis. To Dr Einhorn I said, 'Before starting my next innings, I wanted to thank you for saving my life. Without you this wouldn't have been possible.' I emailed Nurse Jackie and told her that her 'support and smiles' had pulled me through. She wrote back, 'winning hugs coming your way'. I wanted them to have the satisfaction of knowing that I was playing again. I wanted to show them that what they had made me believe could happen had come to be. I wanted them to tell my story to their new patients just like they had told me stories of the people they had treated successfully, which gave me hope. I wanted my story to be a part of the arsenal

in their armoury as they counselled others just stepping into chemo. You will recover and live normally. I wanted that story, my story, to give hope to someone else.

Dr Einhorn's room is decorated with many awards and the citations that he has received for his outstanding work for humanity. His most precious wall he says is the one on which he has messages from people who have survived and gone back to their lives after treatment. I wanted my small story to be there.

In Visakhapatnam I was aching to play, to feel the thump of ball on bat and the racing heart. But all of us have to bow before nature and live with it. I consoled myself thinking I had been given another shot at living and I would have another shot at playing.

Four days later at the Chepauk, I had got to grips. I had sorted out the sequence of training and playing gear. India won the toss against New Zealand and we were going out to field. As the team gathered itself to leave the room, I found myself both heavy and light, excited and anxious, worn down by what I had been through and lifted by where I was. My friends were watching me. One by one Bhajji, Cheeku, Rohit and Zak came up to me and gave me a hug. They were trying to keep it cool and trying not to look emotional, so there was much laughter and much boy-type blabbing: 'good luck, champ', 'king *hai tu, yaar'*, 'go get' 'em', 'welcome back', 'well done'. I knew that if I started to tell them what that gesture meant to me, I would start blubbering.

Out on the grass at the centre of the stadium in the well of the cheering and whistles that Chennai is famous for, I found tears rushing up into my eyes. It's the chemo and the cancer. They've made me emotional. I don't hold back from crying anymore and I will admit to even crying more than before. I also don't believe in the rubbish that it is 'manly' not to cry. Regardless, being seen doing so on a giant electronic screen at the ground would not be cool.

For the rest of that afternoon, I ran like I was fielding everywhere. I wanted to be everywhere—point, short square leg, cover, mid-off, mid-on—and raced around like one of those battery-operated toys that go mad and bang into furniture because you've wound them up too much.

Despite what I thought of as my lightning fielding, New Zealand put up a very good score thanks to Brendon McCullum's fast and furious innings. When it was our turn to bat, I went in at two drop with the score on 86 and less than ten overs left out of twenty. As I stepped into the lights at Chepauk, I was hit in the gut by the sound of the crowd. It was thunderous and tremendous and the stadium was filled with whistles. No crowd in cricket can give an Indian cricketer such a

loud, long and high-pitched whistle of approval as Chepauk does. It is not enough to call the sound whistling in fact. That sound is Indian cricket's *seeti* symphony, performed by an orchestra of about fifty thousand.

That night Chepauk was at its best and the ovation from the crowd almost knocked me off my feet. The occasion, the noise, it made a little jittery. From the corner of my eye, I saw a sign that read 'Yuvi is Back', and I wanted to repay the confidence the crowd had in me with a performance to match.

Mom was in the stands, having missed out on seeing me take the field earlier because her flight to Chennai was diverted for an emergency landing in Nagpur. A little boy was unwell and the non-stop flight had to make a halt. She was sitting in the plane getting fidgety until the flight got clearance to leave Nagpur. She didn't see me first step out on the field at the start of the game but she was there when I went out to bat and she heard the crowd's reception. When she talks about it, she gets goosebumps till this day.

As I started playing, I was a bit edgy for a few balls. The moment a couple hit the middle of my bat, it was like being snapped awake. The doubt and anxiety slipped away. A demanding situation in the middle of a cricket ground with thousands of people cheering. I could do this. When Daniel Vettori floated one outside my off stump my body was moving on its own again. I took a decisive step across the crease, down came the bat and met the ball, my arms following through, and the ball was sent over wide long-on. Six.

I heard the roar of the crowd only in the background because my mind was on the score and the memories in my head were loud. The last time I batted in Chennai, it was March 2011, and we were playing the West Indies in the World Cup. It had been a hot, sweaty day and I had been wobbly. I had been coughing and puking. I remembered the discomfort of that day like it was yesterday.

As MS and I tried to crank up the run rate, it was hard to time our shots and we found we couldn't keep up with the climbing run-rate. We needed 32 from 18 balls, and then 25 from 12, I hit a six and yet we needed 12 in the last over. I was out swinging and missing against James Franklin and eventually we lost by one run. The result did not go our way, but it had been a good game for me. I had bowled two overs for 14 and scored 34 off 24 with a four and two sixes.



A week later the World T20 started in Sri Lanka. It didn't go well for the team. We couldn't get through to the semi-finals. It was a big event. I felt

apprehensive. Would I be all right on the world stage? I realized, yes. There was no stomach-knotting tension. There was no retained memory in my cells of the chemo that six months ago had battered me. I felt cool, calm, confident. I felt ready for victories and defeats. I felt prepared to win but also, and this is important, I felt prepared for the rough days that cricket is full of. It's the rough days that are more daunting. You play cricket for the victories, of course, but the down days are no less significant as a percentage of the life you will spend in the game. I've been through some significant downs in my playing career and have learnt the hard way that appetite is a two-way stretch. You have to want to land the blows but you have to be prepared to take the blows too and you have to be prepared to let them hurt you. Or else work with a briefcase not a bat.

Against Pakistan, I got two wickets, and a direct hit run out which gave me much inner glee, and I hung around at the finish with Cheeku in an eight-wicket victory. The tournament format was such that we needed to win the next match against South Africa by a big margin. We won, but by a single run, and we were out. In that last match I was named Player of the Match. The TV presenter who gave me the prize said, 'There have been some questions about your inclusion …' I kept my emotions in check.

It was from here that I *knew*. I would be ok. I would play, I would be hurt, I would be happy, but I would play and I would be ok.

In cricketing terms, my next step was the longer formats. The Duleep Trophy semi-final game of North Zone versus Central Zone was going to start in Hyderabad. I went there to get the switch mentally and to see myself do ninety overs a day for four days.

Before I went we did the yo-yo cardio test at the NCA. The yo-yo routine tests if you can get through very high amounts of cardio activity with only short breaks in between. It is not a pleasant way to spend your time but I passed it and went to Hyderabad to play in my hundredth first-class match.

North Zone batted first on a run-scoring wicket. My turn came at 2-100 and my first target was to get to 50. If I played around 80-90 balls that would be a good span of batting after so long. Time in the middle, remember, is everything. Once I had crossed 60, I figured 100 would be good to get. As the day wore on, towards the end I started feeling a bit shaky. During a break I called for Ashish, who was in the stadium to keep an eye on me. He gave me a banana to eat. As a matter of habit I don't eat much before batting. He thought my sugar level could be dropping. The banana was like rocket fuel. At stumps I was batting at 133. The next morning, I felt fine, did my stretches and began batting again. In no

time I was past 200. When I got out I had 208, one run less than my highest first-class score. I was out to my good friend Mister Murali Kartik.

Central Zone's batting performance made us stand in the field for two days. I got through one hundred and ten overs, fielding in the slips but not needing any special breaks for a sit-down. At one point we had Central Zone at 9-342. Then Bhuvneshwar Kumar in the tail got stuck. He scored his maiden first-class 100 and with Rituraj Singh took the Central Zone score to 469, past our 451, and they got the points that took them into the Duleep Trophy final.

The next match on my schedule was India A in a three-day practice game against the England team which had arrived in India for the Test series. You may have climbed out of your coffin to return to the field but at the international level you will get no extra sympathy. There will be a lot of respect off the field but on the field the game is the game and everyone's in it to win it. When the game is on, no friendship and no extra yards. In that match I scored a 50 and earned a five-for (including Kevin with a yummy pie). After that came the selection for the Test side against England.



October was coming to an end. Within weeks cricket had consumed my life again. But I noticed the change in me. It was not like it would be when I was younger. Before cancer cricket would have become everything in my life at once. How had I been the entire time when the cancer diagnosis had not come through? Cricket, cricket, cricket. Only wanting to play. Not sparing a thought for my health or the disease. Desperately trying to stay inside the cricket bubble. Once the Test call came the guy I was earlier would have immediately disappeared into the cricket bubble, grateful for its noise and fast-paced life. T20 had started, Test cricket was on the way, I would be in the one-day squad too I could pretty calmly hope. But this time cricket—the cricket life—did not displace everything else. It did not edge out the memory of the battle against cancer and the battle for confidence after that. I did not hold on to the madness of cricket to run from the memory of cancer. Instead I held the legacy of cancer close and got my strength and inner peace from it.

In America, on the way back, and after I returned, I had a lot of time to think. I reflected on my luck. I thought often about that period of confusion before the detection, of being in denial, and then the difficulties of the treatment, and all the help I had got from people around me. When I came back the officials of the

Indian Cancer Society told me that I had unwittingly become the face of cancer and cancer survivorship. This one thing motivated me in my bleakest moments of self-doubt. When I was totally down, I would claw my way to the space where I could ask myself did I not owe it to someone who was sick and watching me, or who had prayed and watched over me when I was sick, to pick myself up and dust myself off and run again? When I was ill I had felt that hope is the rescue rope out of the disease. When the chemical sadness hit me and I cried, when my scalp and skin was covered with the stinging sensation of a billion hairs trying to fall off and I cried, when I had to use a wheelchair and would have preferred to crawl and cried, it was only the hope that this would get over and life would come around again that took me out of those moments of despair.

Back in India I wondered, if I could get back to hitting long and hitting strong, would someone lying in bed watching the game on TV after a long day in a chemo station feel a flicker of excitement and hope, even for a second? I thought they would. For that I had to play my cricket. For them who don't live in cities with hospitals and cars, the millions of poor people in the villages who have no way of detecting what is wrong with them, I would do something else.

I decided to start a cancer charity and named it YOUWECAN. We *can* fight and we must. We *can* win back our lives and our passions. The charity was up and running by July. I went on TV to speak about cancer, to speak to people who had cancer. I wanted to be out there. No hiding, no dodging. I met a lot of families who lived with patients or had lost their loved ones. I started visiting cancer wards in hospitals in the towns I happened to be in. Sharing the pain with the patients was sharing an understanding of what we had been through.

In the course of this work one day in August I was in Mohali on a hospital visit when I met a gentleman who was fifty-eight years old and suffering from liver cancer. He told me, 'Yuvi, it's because of you I am in hospital today.' I was taken aback. What did he mean? He said when the doctors told him he had cancer of the liver he decided he would not get treatment. 'I am fifty-eight. I thought I have lived my life. I won't put myself through the pain of chemotherapy. I will die in peace. Then I was watching the news and I saw that you have been selected for the team. And I thought if this young man can fight cancer and come back like this, how can I give up? I called up my doctor and told him I am ready for chemotherapy.' I was shaken to my soul. From the time I came back from America I had heard so many stories of courage, from young and old, and they each gave me strength. I had to repay that debt of inspiration.



As I wind up this book, we are already in the middle of a busy season of international cricket at home. YOUWECAN is a strong part of my everyday life and my team and I try to do promotional events in the off-days between matches. In the background YOUWECAN is working all the time to see through its plans for mobile cancer detection units for rural India. We think we will do up vans with diagnostic equipment and staff first, which can go to rural areas and hold free screenings. The effort involved is huge. But we will get there. When I am done with cricket, as one day I will have to be, YOUWECAN will become my full-time job.

For now this is the plan. I want to raise awareness about the fact that cancer is not a death sentence. It is not. I want to raise funds for the detection centres. Early detection is half the cure and if people can get simple tests done, it could increase survival numbers by leaps. Getting more detections will help set up a more widespread cancer registry in the country. An in-depth registry will give our doctors a better understanding of our country's cancer map and how the medical community could target treatment infrastructure.

Underlining these plans is this mission: for the rest of my life I want to try to remove the stigma around cancer in India.

I am ready to talk my head off about how ridiculous some preconceptions around cancer can be. Is cancer infectious? Can you go into a house that has a cancer patient and 'catch' it? If a parent has cancer does it mean the children also will? Then should we be marrying our children into a family where there has been cancer? If a businessman has cancer, it must be a bad omen and surely it means his business is going to go bust? Should we do business with someone who has had cancer? Idiotic? Absolutely. The ignorance and superstition around cancer crosses all boundaries of blindness. Even from the most educated and wealthy I have heard this kind of talk. Not to mention the fact that even the cleverest, most intelligent, most well-travelled will often not want to deal with their cancer, preferring to take some quack at his word that alternative therapy has a cure rather than submit to straightforward medicine. Cancer is bad enough. Why also get silly?

Dr Nitesh once said something to me that was funny and at the same time sensible. He said human beings by and large are basically stone-age people. Or when he wants to be kinder, he says, 'We are not very far from stone-age people.' He means we find it as hard to deal with our normal stresses as at any other time in human history. Cancer patients, he says, are different. They have

faced and come through the fear of death and they learn from that experience to simplify their lives and often find themselves emotionally in a better place. I notice that cancer has made me a less anxious person. More than one cricketer who survived cancer and returned to the game didn't succeed. It could happen to me. I can deal with this thought and not feel weakened by it.

Meanwhile I can look around me and appreciate my life today. It is filled with happiness and gratitude. I have my family, my friends. Over and above that I play the game again. I have received the gift of joy and opportunity in abundance and I tell myself now you can't be angry and you can't be greedy. I went into my first match for India with no expectations. If I fail, I fail. If I succeed, I succeed. I really want to succeed but if I fail, it will be without any regrets. If I succeed, it will be without any swagger.

It has been a few months since then. I have been wearing my blue India jersey quite a lot this season and note happily that it fits me perfectly. In this time Test cricket has given me a glimpse of its hardships and its treasures. I will have to prove myself all over again. But I see that I have been given a second chance in life and I know that I intend to spend it running. If I fall, as I will, I look forward to dusting myself off and running again. That I can do.

There you go, folks. Yuvraj Singh 2012 is a post-stone-age man. If Yuvi can, you can.

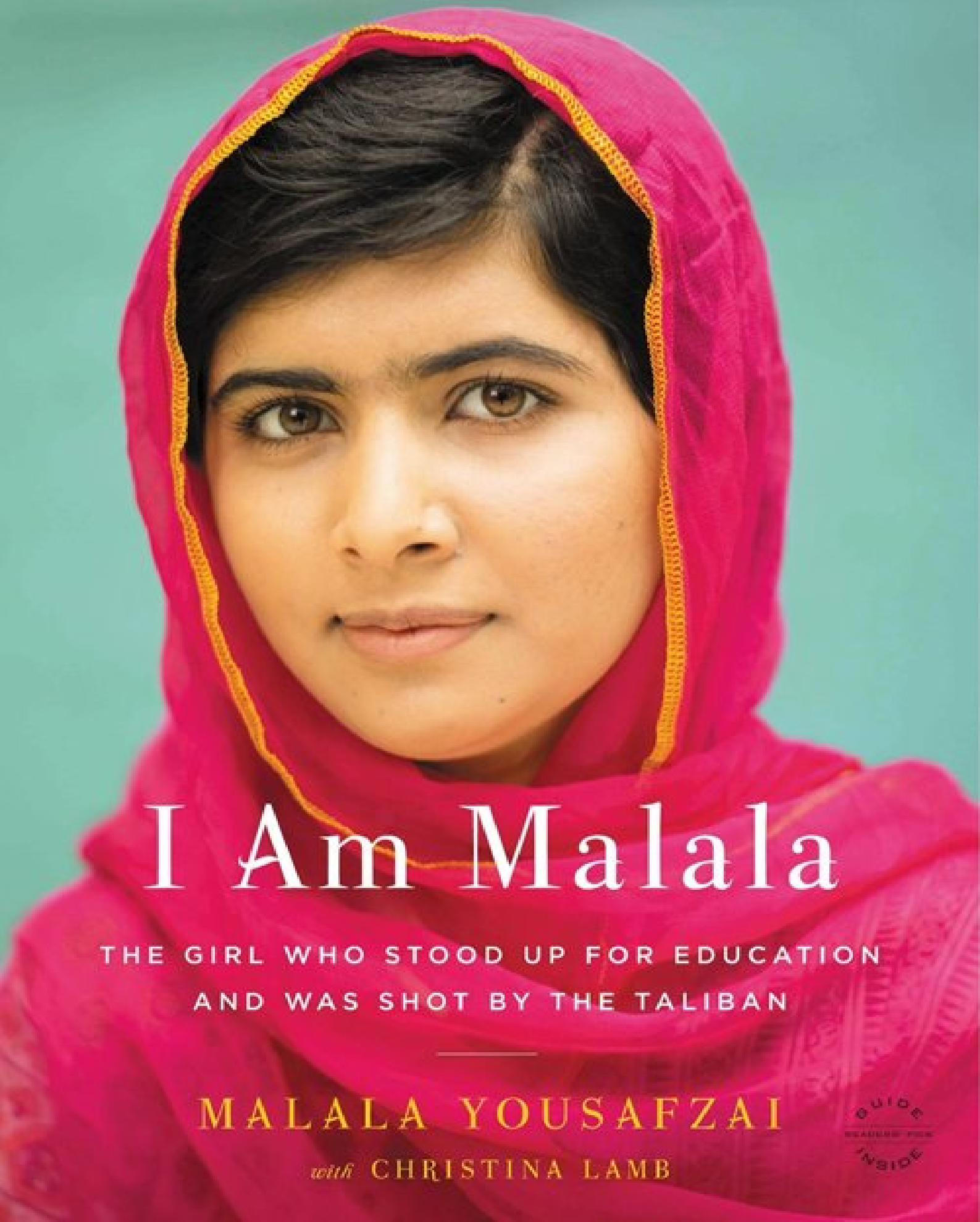
A Note on the Author

YUVRAJ SINGH is an Indian cricketer and a cancer survivor. He was born in Chandigarh in 1981. He debuted for India in 2000 during the ICC Knock Out Trophy, still only nineteen. In 2011, he emerged as Player of the Tournament in the ICC World Cup, which his team won. That same year he was diagnosed with cancer. He returned to international cricket less than a year after his diagnosis.

This is his first book.

NATIONAL BESTSELLER

"Riveting....It is difficult to imagine a chronicle of a war more moving, apart from perhaps the diary of Anne Frank." —*WASHINGTON POST*



I Am Malala

THE GIRL WHO STOOD UP FOR EDUCATION AND WAS SHOT BY THE TALIBAN

MALALA YOUSAFZAI

with CHRISTINA LAMB

GUIDE INSIDE


HCL
$CaCO_3$
$H+O_2 \rightarrow H_2O$
$NaCl_2$
trachea
lungs
Vernier
Calipers

I AM MALALA

The Girl Who Stood Up for Education and was Shot by the Taliban

Malala Yousafzai
with Christina Lamb

Weidenfeld & Nicolson
LONDON


Map of Swat, Pakistan, and surrounding areas
AFGHANISTAN
20 kms
SWAT
Swat R.
SHANGLA
Karshat
Shahpur
Barkana
Matta
Mingora
Alpuri
Imam Deri
(Fazlullah's HQ)
Malakand
TAJIKISTAN
CHINA
Line of control
BAJAUR
Kabul
Mardan
Tora Bora
Abbottabad
KASHMIR
Peshawar
Islamabad
Rawalpindi
AFGHANISTAN
WAZIRISTAN
Kandahar
Lahore
Quetta
PAKISTAN
INDIA
IRAN
N
Karachi
0 100 200 300 miles
0 200 400 kms
ARABIAN SEA

EPILOGUE

One Child, One Teacher, One Book, One Pen . . .

Birmingham, August 2013

IN MARCH WE moved from the apartment to a rented house on a leafy street, but it feels as if we are camping in it. All our belongings are still in Swat. Everywhere there are cardboard boxes full of the kind letters and cards that people send, and in one room stands a piano none of us can play. My mother complains about the murals of Greek gods on the walls and carved cherubs on the ceilings watching her.

Our house feels big and empty. It sits behind an electric iron gate and it sometimes seems as if we are in what we in Pakistan call a sub-jail, a kind of luxury house arrest. At the back there is a large garden with lots of trees and a green lawn for me and my brothers to play cricket on. But there are no rooftops to play on, no children fighting with kites in the streets, no neighbours coming in to borrow a plate of rice or for us to ask for three tomatoes. We are just a wall's distance from the next house but it feels miles away.

If I look out, I see my mother wandering around the garden, her head covered by a shawl, feeding the birds. She looks as if she is singing, maybe that *tapa* she likes: 'Don't kill doves in the garden./ You kill one and the others won't come.' She is giving the birds the remains of our dinner from the night before and there are tears in her eyes. We eat much the same here as we did back home – rice and meat for lunch and dinner, while breakfast is fried eggs, chapatis and sometimes also honey, a tradition started by my little brother Atal, though his favourite Birmingham discovery is Nutella sandwiches. But there are always leftovers. My mother is sad about the waste of food. I know she is remembering all the children we fed in our house, so they would not go to school on empty stomachs, and wondering how they are faring now.

When I came home from school in Mingora I never found my house without people in it; now I can't believe that I used to plead for a day of peace and some privacy to do my school work. Here the only sound is of the birds and Khushal's Xbox. I sit alone in my room doing a jigsaw puzzle and long for guests.

We didn't have much money and my parents knew what it was like to be hungry. My mother never turned anyone away. Once a poor woman came, hot, hungry and thirsty, to our door. My mother let her in and gave her food and the woman was so happy. 'I touched every door in the *mohalla* and this was the only one open,' she said. 'May God always keep your door open, wherever you are.'

I know my mother is lonely. She was very sociable – all the women of the neighbourhood used to gather in the afternoons on our back porch and women who worked in other houses came to rest. Now she is always on the phone to everyone back home. It's hard for her here as she does not speak any English. Our house has all these facilities, but when she arrived they were all mysteries to her and someone had to show us how to use the oven, washing machine and the TV.

As usual my father doesn't help in the kitchen. I tease him, '*Aba*, you talk of women's rights, but my mother manages everything! You don't even clear the tea things.'

There are buses and trains but we are unsure about using them. My mother misses going shopping in Cheena Bazaar. She is happier since my cousin Shah came to stay. He has a car and takes her shopping, but it's not the same as she can't talk to her friends and neighbours about what she bought.

A door bangs in the house and my mother jumps – she jumps these days at the slightest noise. She often cries then hugs me'. 'Malala is alive,' she says. Now she treats me as if I was her youngest rather than eldest child.

I know my father cries too. He cries when I push my hair to the side and he sees the scar on my head, and he cries when he wakes from an afternoon nap to hear his children's voices in the garden and realises with relief that one of them is still mine. He knows people say it's his fault that I was shot, that he pushed me to speak up like a tennis dad trying to create a champion, as if I don't have my own mind. It's hard for him. All he worked for for over almost twenty years has been left behind: the school he built up from nothing, which now has three buildings with

1,100 pupils and seventy teachers. I know he felt proud at what he had created, a poor boy from that narrow village between the Black and White Mountains. He says, ‘It’s as if you planted a tree and nurtured it – you have the right to sit in its shade.’

His dream in life was to have a very big school in Swat providing quality education, to live peacefully and to have democracy in our country. In Swat he had achieved respect and status in society through his activities and the help he gave people. He never imagined living abroad and he gets upset when people suggest we wanted to come to the UK. ‘A person who has eighteen years of education, a nice life, a family, you throw him out just as you throw a fish out of water for speaking up for girls’ education?’ Sometimes he says we have gone from being IDPs to EDPs – externally displaced persons. Often over meals we talk about home and try to remember things. We miss everything, even the smelly stream. My father says, ‘If I had known this would happen, I would have looked back for a last time just as the Prophet did when he left Mecca to migrate to Medina. He looked back again and again.’ Already some of the things from Swat seem like stories from a distant place, like somewhere I have read about.

My father spends much of his time going to conferences on education. I know it’s odd for him that now people want to hear him because of me, not the other way round. I used to be known as his daughter; now he’s known as my father. When he went to France to collect an award for me he told the audience, ‘In my part of the world most people are known by their sons. I am one of the few lucky fathers known by his daughter.’

A smart new uniform hangs on my bedroom door, bottle green instead of royal blue, for a school where no one dreams of being attacked for going to classes or someone blowing up the building. In April I was well enough to start school in Birmingham. It’s wonderful going to school and not having to feel scared as I did in Mingora, always looking around me on my way to school, terrified a *talib* would jump out.

It’s a good school. Many subjects are the same as at home, but the teachers have PowerPoint and computers rather than chalk and blackboards. We have some different subjects – music, art, computer studies, home economics, where we learn to cook – and we do practicals in science, which is rare in Pakistan. Even though I recently got just forty percent in my physics exam, it is still my favourite subject. I love

learning about Newton and the basic principles the whole universe obeys.

But like my mother I am lonely. It takes time to make good friends like I had at home, and the girls at school here treat me differently. People say, ‘Oh, that’s Malala’ – they see me as ‘Malala, girls’ rights activist’. Back in the Khushal School I was just Malala, the same double-jointed girl they had always known, who loved to tell jokes and drew pictures to explain things. Oh, and who was always quarrelling with her brother and best friend! I think every class has a very well behaved girl, a very intelligent or genius girl, a very popular girl, a beautiful girl, a girl who is a bit shy, a notorious girl . . . but here I haven’t worked out yet who is who.

As there is no one here I can tell my jokes to, I save them and tell them to Moniba when we Skype. My first question is always, ‘What’s the latest news at the school?’ I love to hear who is fighting with who, and who got told off by which teacher. Moniba came first in class in the most recent exams. My classmates still keep the seat for me with my name on it, and at the boys’ school Sir Amjad has put a big poster of me at the entrance and says he greets it every morning before going into his office.

I describe life in England to Moniba. I tell her of the streets with rows of identical houses, unlike home, where everything is different and higgledy-piggledy and a shack of mud and stones can stand next to a house as big as a castle. I tell her how they are lovely solid houses which could withstand floods and earthquakes but have no flat roofs to play on. I tell her I like England because people follow rules, they respect policemen and everything happens on time. The government is in charge and no one needs to know the name of the army chief. I see women having jobs we couldn’t imagine in Swat. They are police and security guards; they run big companies and dress exactly as they like.

I don’t often think about the shooting, though every day when I look in the mirror it is a reminder. The nerve operation has done as much as it can. I will never be exactly the same. I can’t blink fully and my left eye closes a lot when I speak. My father’s friend Hidayatullah told him we should be proud of my eye. ‘It’s the beauty of her sacrifice,’ he said.

It is still not definitely known who shot me, but a man named Ataullah Khan said he did it. The police have not managed to find him but they say they are investigating and want to interview me.

Though I don't remember exactly what happened that day, sometimes I have flashbacks. They come unexpectedly. The worst one was in June, when we were in Abu Dhabi on the way to perform *Umrah* in Saudi Arabia. I went to a shopping mall with my mother as she wanted to buy a special burqa to pray in Mecca. I didn't want one. I said I would just wear my shawl as it is not specified that a woman must wear a burqa. As we were walking through the mall, suddenly I could see so many men around me. I thought they were waiting for me with guns and would shoot. I was terrified though I said nothing. I told myself, *Malala, you have already faced death. This is your second life. Don't be afraid – if you are afraid you can't move forward.*

We believe that when we have our first sight of the Kaaba, the black-shrouded cube in Mecca that is our most sacred place, any wish in your heart is granted by God. When we prayed at the Kaaba, we prayed for peace in Pakistan and for girls' education, and I was surprised to find myself in tears. But when we went to the other holy places in the desert of Mecca where the Prophet lived and preached, I was shocked that they were littered with empty bottles and biscuit wrappers. It seemed that people had neglected to preserve history. I thought they had forgotten the Hadith that cleanliness is half of faith.

My world has changed so much. On the shelves of our rented living room are awards from around the world – America, India, France, Spain, Italy and Austria, and many other places. I've even been nominated for the Nobel Peace Prize, the youngest person ever. When I received prizes for my work at school I was happy as I had worked hard for them, but these prizes are different. I am grateful for them, but they only remind me how much work still needs to be done to achieve the goal of education for every boy and girl. I don't want to be thought of as 'the girl who was shot by the Taliban' but 'the girl who fought for education'. This is the cause to which I want to devote my life.

On my sixteenth birthday I was in New York to speak at the United Nations. Standing up to address an audience inside the vast hall where so many world leaders have spoken before was daunting, but I knew what I wanted to say. 'This is your chance Malala,' I said to myself. Only 400 people were sitting around me, but when I looked out, I imagined millions more. I did not write the speech only with the UN delegates in mind; I wrote it for every person around the world who could make a difference. I wanted to reach all people living in poverty, those children

forced to work and those who suffer from terrorism or lack of education. Deep in my heart I hoped to reach every child who could take courage from my words and stand up for his or her rights.

I wore one of Benazir Bhutto's white shawls over my favourite pink shalwar kamiz and I called on the world's leaders to provide free education to every child in the world. 'Let us pick up our books and our pens,' I said. 'They are our most powerful weapons. One child, one teacher, one book and one pen can change the world.' I didn't know how my speech was received until the audience gave me a standing ovation. My mother was in tears and my father said I had become everybody's daughter.

Something else happened that day. My mother allowed herself to be publicly photographed for the first time. As she has lived her life in purdah and never unveiled her face on camera before, it was a great sacrifice and very difficult for her.

At breakfast the next day Atal said to me in the hotel, 'Malala, I don't understand why you are famous. What have you done?' All the time we were in New York he was more excited by the Statue of Liberty, Central Park and his favourite game Beyblade!

After the speech I received messages of support from all over the world, but there was mostly silence from my own country, except that on Twitter and Facebook we could see my own Pakistani brothers and sisters turning against me. They accused me of speaking out of 'a teen lust for fame'. One said, 'Forget the image of your country, forget about the school. She would eventually get what she was after, a life of luxury abroad.'

I don't mind. I know people say these things because they have seen leaders and politicians in our country who make promises they never keep. Instead things in Pakistan are getting worse every day. The endless terrorist attacks have left the whole nation in shock. People have lost trust in each other, but I would like everyone to know that I don't want support for myself, I want the support to be for my cause of peace and education.

The most surprising letter I got after my speech was from a Taliban commander who recently escaped from prison. His name was Adnan Rashid and he used to be in the Pakistan air force. He had been in jail since 2003 for attempting to assassinate President Musharraf. He said the Taliban had attacked me not for my campaign for education but because

I tried to ‘malign [their] efforts to establish the Islamic system’. He said he was writing to me because he was shocked by my shooting and wished he could have warned me beforehand. He wrote that they would forgive me if I came back to Pakistan, wore a burqa and went to a madrasa.

Journalists urged me to answer him, but I thought, *Who is this man to say that?* The Taliban are not our rulers. It’s my life, how I live it is my choice. But Mohammed Hanif wrote an article pointing out that the good thing about the Taliban letter was that many people claim I wasn’t shot yet here they were accepting responsibility.

I know I will go back to Pakistan, but whenever I tell my father I want to go home, he finds excuses. ‘ No, *Jani*, your treatment is not complete,’ he says, or, ‘These schools are good. You should stay here and gather knowledge so you can use your words powerfully.’

He is right. I want to learn and be trained well with the weapon of knowledge. Then I will be able to fight more effectively for my cause.

Today we all know education is our basic right. Not just in the West; Islam too has given us this right. Islam says every girl and every boy should go to school. In the Quran it is written, God wants us to have knowledge. He wants us to know why the sky is blue and about oceans and stars. I know it’s a big struggle – around the world there are fifty-seven million children who are not in primary school, thirty-two million of them girls. Sadly my own country Pakistan is one of the worst places: 5.1 million children don’t even go to primary school even though in our constitution it says every child has that right. We have almost fifty million illiterate adults, two-thirds of whom are women, like my own mother.

Girls continue to be killed and schools blown up. In March there was an attack on a girls’ school in Karachi that we had visited. A bomb and a grenade were tossed into the school playground just as a prize-giving ceremony was about to start. The headmaster, Abdur Rasheed, was killed and eight children hurt between the ages of five and ten. One eight-year-old was left disabled. When my mother heard the news, she cried and cried. ‘When our children are sleeping we wouldn’t even disturb a hair on their heads,’ she said, ‘but there are people who have guns and shoot them or hurl bombs. They don’t care that their victims are children.’ The most shocking attack was in June in the city of Quetta when a suicide bomber blew up a bus taking forty pupils to their all-girls’ college.

Fourteen of them were killed. The wounded were followed to the hospital and some nurses were shot.

It's not just the Taliban killing children. Sometimes it's drone attacks, sometimes it's wars, sometimes it's hunger. And sometimes it's their own family. In June two girls my age were murdered in Gilgit, which is a little north of Swat, for posting a video online showing themselves dancing in the rain wearing traditional dress and headscarves. Apparently their own stepbrother shot them.

Today Swat is more peaceful than other places, but there are still military everywhere, four years after they supposedly removed the Taliban. Fazlullah is still on the loose and our bus driver still under house arrest. Our valley, which was once a haven for tourists, is now seen as a place of fear. Foreigners who want to visit have to get a No Objection Certificate from the authorities in Islamabad. Hotels and craft shops are empty. It will be a long time before tourists return.

Over the last year I've seen many other places, but my valley remains to me the most beautiful place in the world. I don't know when I will see it again but I know that I will. I wonder what happened to the mango seed I planted in our garden at Ramadan. I wonder if anyone is watering it so that one day future generations of daughters and sons can enjoy its fruit.

Today I looked at myself in a mirror and thought for a second. Once I had asked God for one or two extra inches in height, but instead he made me as tall as the sky, so high that I could not measure myself. So I offered the hundred *raakat nafl* prayers that I had promised if I grew.

I love my God. I thank my Allah. I talk to him all day. He is the greatest. By giving me this height to reach people, he has also given me great responsibilities. Peace in every home, every street, every village, every country – this is my dream. Education for every boy and every girl in the world. To sit down on a chair and read my books with all my friends at school is my right. To see each and every human being with a smile of happiness is my wish.

I am Malala. My world has changed but I have not.

UNIT II – Reflections Through Verse

- **The Rainy Day - H. W. Longfellow**
- **Our Casuarina Tree – Toru Dutt**
- **If – Rudyard Kipling**

The Rainy Day – By Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

About the Poet:

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow (February 27, 1807 – March 24, 1882) was an American poet and educator. His original works include the poems "Paul Revere's Ride", The Song of Hiawatha, and Evangeline. His work often explored themes of history, mythology, and romantic love, drawing inspiration from European literary traditions. He was a leading figure in the American Romantic movement, alongside contemporaries such as Nathaniel Hawthorne and Edgar Allan Poe. Longfellow's poems were widely read and memorized, solidifying his status as a beloved literary figure in his lifetime.

The Rainy Day

The day is cold, and dark, and dreary;
It rains, and the wind is never weary;
The vine still clings to the mouldering wall,
But at every gust the dead leaves fall,
And the day is dark and dreary.

My life is cold, and dark, and dreary;
It rains, and the wind is never weary;
My thoughts still cling to the mouldering past,
But the hopes of youth fall thick in the blast,
And the days are dark and dreary.

Be still, sad heart, and cease repining;
Behind the clouds is the sun still shining;
Thy fate is the common fate of all,
Into each life some rain must fall,
Some days must be dark and dreary.

Our Casuarina Tree – By Toru Dutt

About the Poet:

Toru Dutt, born on March 4, 1856, in Kolkata, India, was a translator, poet, and essayist. She is the author of Ancient Ballads and Legends of Hindustan (Kegan Paul, Trench & Co., 1882) and Le Journal de Mademoiselle d'Arvers (Didier, 1879), the first novel written by an Indian writer in French. A prolific translator, she published A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields (C. Kegan Paul & Co., 1877), a book of over three hundred French poems translated into English. She died on August 30, 1877, at the age of twenty-one.

Our Casuarina Tree

LIKE a huge Python, winding round and round
The rugged trunk, indented deep with scars,
Up to its very summit near the stars,
A creeper climbs, in whose embraces bound
No other tree could live. But gallantly
The giant wears the scarf, and flowers are hung
In crimson clusters all the boughs among,
Whereon all day are gathered bird and bee;
And oft at nights the garden overflows
With one sweet song that seems to have no close,
Sung darkling from our tree, while men repose.

When first my casement is wide open thrown
At dawn, my eyes delighted on it rest;
Sometimes, and most in winter,—on its crest
A gray baboon sits statue-like alone
Watching the sunrise; while on lower boughs
His puny offspring leap about and play;
And far and near kokilas hail the day;
And to their pastures wend our sleepy cows;
And in the shadow, on the broad tank cast
By that hoar tree, so beautiful and vast,
The water-lilies spring, like snow enmassed.

But not because of its magnificence
Dear is the Casuarina to my soul:
Beneath it we have played; though years may roll,
O sweet companions, loved with love intense,
For your sakes, shall the tree be ever dear.
Blent with your images, it shall arise
In memory, till the hot tears blind mine eyes!
What is that dirge-like murmur that I hear
Like the sea breaking on a shingle-beach?
It is the tree's lament, an eerie speech,
That haply to the unknown land may reach.

Unknown, yet well-known to the eye of faith!
Ah, I have heard that wail far, far away

In distant lands, by many a sheltered bay,
When slumbered in his cave the water-wraith
And the waves gently kissed the classic shore
Of France or Italy, beneath the moon,
When earth lay trancèd in a dreamless swoon:
And every time the music rose,—before
Mine inner vision rose a form sublime,
Thy form, O Tree, as in my happy prime
I saw thee, in my own loved native clime.

Therefore I fain would consecrate a lay
Unto thy honor, Tree, beloved of those
Who now in blessed sleep for aye repose,—
Dearer than life to me, alas, were they!
Mayst thou be numbered when my days are done
With deathless trees—like those in Borrowdale,
Under whose awful branches lingered pale
"Fear, trembling Hope, and Death, the skeleton,
And Time the shadow;" and though weak the verse
That would thy beauty fain, oh, fain rehearse,
May Love defend thee from Oblivion's curse.

If --- By Rudyard Kipling

About the Poet:

Joseph Rudyard Kipling (30 December 1865 – 18 January 1936) was an English journalist, novelist, poet and short-story writer. He was born in British India, which inspired much of his work. Kipling's works of fiction include the Jungle Book duology (The Jungle Book, 1894; The Second Jungle Book, 1895), Kim (1901), the Just So Stories (1902) and many short stories, including "The Man Who Would Be King" (1888).[2] His poems include "Mandalay" (1890), "Gunga Din" (1890), "The Gods of the Copybook Headings" (1919), "The White Man's Burden" (1899) and "If—" (1910). He is seen as an innovator in the art of the short story. His children's books are classics; one critic noted "a versatile and luminous narrative gift".

If—

(‘Brother Square-Toes’—Rewards and Fairies)

If you can keep your head when all about you
  Are losing theirs and blaming it on you,
If you can trust yourself when all men doubt you,
  But make allowance for their doubting too;
If you can wait and not be tired by waiting,
  Or being lied about, don’t deal in lies,
Or being hated, don’t give way to hating,
  And yet don’t look too good, nor talk too wise:

If you can dream—and not make dreams your master;
  If you can think—and not make thoughts your aim;
If you can meet with Triumph and Disaster
  And treat those two impostors just the same;
If you can bear to hear the truth you’ve spoken
  Twisted by knaves to make a trap for fools,
Or watch the things you gave your life to, broken,
  And stoop and build ’em up with worn-out tools:

If you can make one heap of all your winnings
  And risk it on one turn of pitch-and-toss,
And lose, and start again at your beginnings
  And never breathe a word about your loss;
If you can force your heart and nerve and sinew
  To serve your turn long after they are gone,
And so hold on when there is nothing in you
  Except the Will which says to them: ‘Hold on!’

If you can talk with crowds and keep your virtue,
  Or walk with Kings—nor lose the common touch,
If neither foes nor loving friends can hurt you,
  If all men count with you, but none too much;
If you can fill the unforgiving minute
  With sixty seconds’ worth of distance run,
Yours is the Earth and everything that’s in it,
  And—which is more—you’ll be a Man, my son!